

ZIHANG LI

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ABD, available from May 2027

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EDUCATION

Auburn University

July 2027 expected

Ph.D. in Applied Economics; ABD.

Auburn University — M.S., Applied Economics

May 2025

Konkuk University, South Korea — M.A., Economics

February 2021

Harbin University of Science and Technology, China — Bachelor of Management, Accounting August 2018

RESEARCH FIELDS

Health Economics; Industrial Organization; Applied Microeconomics.

WORKING PAPERS

Psychiatric Medication Use at the Medicaid Eligibility Threshold in States with Separate CHIP

Sole-authored job market paper; under review at Health Economics.

Abstract. Uses local-linear regression discontinuities in the 2016–2019, 2021–2022, and 2024 National Survey of Children’s Health for children ages 6–17 in separate-CHIP states. At the income threshold, children remain eligible for public insurance, but the administering program, coverage terms, provider networks, and transition procedures can change. Psychiatric-medication use is 9.7 percentage points higher just above the threshold before the pandemic, 16.9 points higher during the federal enrollment freeze, and 7.5 points higher in 2024. Before and during the freeze, the difference is concentrated among children with a current mental, emotional, developmental, or behavioral diagnosis, while uninsurance does not change detectably. The paper establishes the Medicaid-to-separate-CHIP boundary as a new empirical setting and tracks medication use across three federal enrollment regimes, shifting attention from insurance status to continuity in behavioral-health care.

Market Authorization Holder (MAH) Pilot Program and Innovation Investment in China’s Pharmaceutical Industry

First and corresponding author; with Tannista Banerjee, Aditi Sengupta, and Shan He; preparing for submission to International Journal of Industrial Organization.

Abstract. Uses difference-in-differences, triple-difference, and Poisson DID models with Chinese pharmaceutical patent data from 2015–2021 to study the 2016 Market Authorization Holder reform. By separating drug marketing rights from manufacturing, the reform changed the institutional setting in which firms organize production and choose innovation investments. It increased patent authorizations, backward citations, and patent claims among non-Traditional Chinese Medicine firms, with no significant effects for Traditional Chinese Medicine firms. Comparing responses across firm types shows why a common deregulation need not produce uniform innovation effects and contributes evidence on how regulatory design shapes corporate innovation in an emerging pharmaceutical market.

A Challenger Reward That Almost Never Pays: Patent Declarations, Invalidation, and Procurement under China’s Drug Patent Linkage System, 2021–2026

Sole-authored working paper.

Abstract. Uses all 23,129 patent positions on China’s national drug patent declaration platform, CNIPA invalidation decisions, and volume-based procurement (VBP) rules to describe how the 2021 linkage system’s challenger reward works in practice. The reward—up to twelve months of exclusivity for the first approved generic whose own invalidation request succeeds—had been publicly awarded twice as of September 2026, both times to one firm group, although declarants won whole invalidations of 16 declared patents. Most contesting instead asserts non-infringement against later-expiring formulation patents, a route the reward does not cover: in 99.4% of within-application comparisons, that assertion falls on the longer-lived patent. Because VBP rules count non-infringement undertakings, the patent statements with direct consequences for sales are procurement undertakings. All results are descriptive.

Adverse Childhood Experiences and Co-occurring Physical–Mental Health Conditions in U.S. Children: Evidence from the National Survey of Children’s Health

With Sanket Kanekar; working paper.

Abstract. Uses survey-weighted multinomial logistic regressions with the 2022–2024 NSCH. At four or more adverse childhood experiences, the relative risk ratio is 9.77 for co-occurring conditions, 7.43 for mental-only conditions, and 1.90 for physical-only conditions, showing how adversity is associated with the joint distribution of physical and mental health.

WORK IN PROGRESS

- Food Deserts and Health Outcomes: Evidence from HCUP, 2012–2022 (with Ruchika Rungta).
- Classifying Product versus Process Innovation in Chinese Pharmaceutical and Medical Device Patents: A Novel PatentBERT–LLM Methodology.
- Hiring at the Floor: The H-1B Program and the Wages of Foreign-Born Allied-Health Workers (with Sanket Kanekar).
- Rationing by Lottery and the Economics of Gaming: Multiple Registration in the H-1B Visa Program, FY2021–FY2024 (with Sanket Kanekar).

TEACHING INTERESTS

Microeconomics; Macroeconomics; Econometrics; Business Statistics; Data Analytics;
Health Economics; Industrial Organization.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Independent Instructor (instructor of record), Auburn University *2023–2026*

Full responsibility for syllabi, instruction, assessment, and grading across five terms.

- ECON 2020, Principles of Microeconomics: Fall 2023 (33 students), Spring 2025 (25), Summer 2026 (20).
- ECON 2030, Principles of Macroeconomics: Spring 2024 (42 students), Spring 2026 (41).

Module Instructor, Auburn University *Spring 2025*

ECON 5700/6700, Health Economics: undergraduate and graduate modules (20 students).

Teaching Assistant, Auburn University *2021–present*

Supported principles courses of 200–425 students and led Econometrics recitations.

- ECON 2020, Principles of Microeconomics: Fall 2021, Spring 2022, Fall 2022, Summer 2025.
- ECON 2030, Principles of Macroeconomics: Fall 2021, Spring 2022, Fall 2022.
- ECON 4600, Econometrics: Fall 2024 (17 students), Fall 2025 (6). Led weekly R recitations and guided IPUMS projects from research design through analysis and code debugging.
- Fall 2026: joined the coordinated office-hour team for a multi-section principles sequence serving approximately 1,800 students; helped newer TAs prepare for common questions.

Teaching Assistant, Konkuk University *2018–2020*

Environmental Economics, Microeconomics, Macroeconomics, and History of Economic Thought (200+ students).

Graduate Mentor, Konkuk University *Fall 2019*

Research for Undergraduate Study program.

Teaching evaluations: Overall ratings of 5.03–5.33/6.0 in my four most recent independently taught principles courses; Econometrics TA ratings of 5.39 (Fall 2024) and 5.86 (Fall 2025); details in the evaluation summary.

COURSE DESIGN AND TEACHING DEVELOPMENT

- Developed instructional web applications: *Oligopoly*, *Tulip Bulb Investment Game*, and *Welfare Lab*.
- Used polls, Padlet, and guided practice; expanded problem solving after Spring 2026 midsemester feedback.
- Completed Auburn's Biggio Center Course (Re)Design Program in Summer 2024 and Summer 2026.

GRANT PROPOSAL EXPERIENCE

NSF HBCU-EiR Proposal, Graduate Research Lead (internal role) October 2025

Economic Evaluation of AI-Powered Virtual Reality Wellness Platforms: Enhancing Accessibility, Engagement, and Cost-Effectiveness in Mental Health Support.

PI: Sanket Kanekar (Alabama State); co-PIs: Kimberly Garza and Travis Evans (Auburn).

- Led proposal writing, budget development, and administrative coordination; co-developed the randomized trial and economic evaluation; built the VR prototype and AI pipeline.
- Not funded; reviewers encouraged resubmission, and the team is revising it for NIH/NIMH.

PRESENTATIONS

Southern Economic Association: Houston, TX (2026, scheduled); Tampa, FL (2025); Washington, DC (2024).

Western Economic Association International: Denver, CO (2026); San Francisco, CA (2025).

American Society of Health Economists: Minneapolis, MN (2026).

Auburn University: Three-Minute Thesis (2024); Outreach and Engaged Scholarship Symposium (2024).

HONORS AND AWARDS

Graduate Fellowship, Department of Economics, Auburn University 2021–present

Graduate Tuition Scholarship, Konkuk University 2018–2021

Research for Undergraduate Study Grant, Konkuk University 2019

SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

Software: R, Stata, Python, L^AT_EX.

Languages: Korean (native), Chinese (native), English (fluent).

REFERENCES

Peng Shao

(Teaching reference)

Assistant Professor of Economics
Auburn University
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Tannista Banerjee

(Dissertation chair)

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Auburn University
tzb0018@auburn.edu

Hyeongwoo Kim

(Committee member)

Patrick E. Molony Professor
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Aditi Sengupta

(Committee member)

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Auburn University
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Kimberly B. Garza

(University reader)

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Outcomes Research and Policy
Harrison College of Pharmacy,
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